

THE COLLECTED BOOKS OF TASTE

The Patisserie of the Unconscious

Five desserts.

Five ways of tasting life.



HISTORY · AFTERTASTE · RECIPE

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A BOOK OF TASTE / I

The Patisserie of the Unconscious

Madeleine

MEMORY



Memory keeps what biography forgets.

The Court Kitchen

c. 1750 · Commercy



The origin of the madeleine is wrapped in legend. The history preserved in Commercy links the small shell-shaped cake to the kitchens of Stanislas around 1750, although its precise inventor remains unknown.

One popular story gives the cake the name of a young servant, Madeleine, who prepared it when a royal dinner was left without dessert. Whether or not the scene happened exactly this way, the legend places the pastry between domestic knowledge and the theatre of the court.

From Secret to Craft

1766 — *early 19th century* · Commercy



After Stanislas died in 1766, one of his pastry cooks is said to have settled in Commercy and carried the recipe into local trade.

During the nineteenth century, the number of madeleine makers increased. The cake was no longer only a courtly curiosity: it became a town craft, produced by families of bakers and sold by the dozen.

A recipe once surrounded by secrecy gradually became part of the identity of a place.

The Railway Cake

1852 — 1874 · Paris — Commercy — Strasbourg



The railway transformed the madeleine from a local speciality into a travelling object.

The Paris–Strasbourg line reached Commercy in 1852. Later, vendors were officially allowed to sell boxes of madeleines on the station platform.

During the short stop, the cakes were passed through open carriage windows. They travelled in wooden boxes, entered Parisian homes, and became an edible souvenir of modern movement.

The madeleine was now not only baked in a place. It carried that place elsewhere.

Proust's Madeleine

1913 · *Combray*



In the first volume of *In Search of Lost Time*, published in 1913, the narrator tastes a piece of madeleine softened in lime-blossom tea.

The sensation does not produce an immediate explanation. First comes an intense, mysterious pleasure. Only afterwards does the forgotten world of Combray return: the house, the streets, the garden, the Sunday mornings and the rooms of childhood.

The object was not inevitable. In early drafts, Proust experimented with toast and rusk before choosing the madeleine.

Through this scene, a regional cake became a cultural metaphor for involuntary memory: the moment when the body remembers before the conscious mind knows what it has found.

AFTERTASTE

A local cake had become a way of thinking about time.

A SMALL PRACTICE

Prepare tea without your phone nearby. Try to remember not an event, but the atmosphere of a place: its light, smell, texture, and hour.

What part of your life would you return to through a taste?

RECIPE / INGREDIENTS

Classic Madeleines

A classic home recipe.

- 2 large eggs
- 100 g sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 120 g all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 100 g melted butter
- 1 tbsp milk
- zest of 1 lemon
- pinch of salt



RECIPE / METHOD

- 01 Heat the oven to 190°C / 375°F and grease a madeleine pan.
 - 02 Whisk eggs and sugar until pale.
 - 03 Add vanilla, lemon zest, milk, and salt.
 - 04 Fold in flour and baking powder.
 - 05 Mix in the melted butter.
 - 06 Rest the batter for 20–30 minutes.
 - 07 Fill each mold three-quarters full.
 - 08 Bake for 9–11 minutes until lightly golden.
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The madeleine needs only a few ingredients, but its cultural life was assembled over centuries.

A BOOK OF TASTE / II

The Patisserie of the Unconscious

Cannoli

PLEASURE



Even restraint can invent sweetness.

HISTORY / 01

The Arab Gift

9th — 11th century · Sicily



Under Arab rule, Sicily received sugarcane, citrus, almonds and the art of working them — the foundation of everything sweet the island would later invent.

Ricotta, sugar and spice met on the same table for the first time. The cannolo did not yet exist, but its ingredients had already arrived.

HISTORY / 02

Behind the Convent Grille

Medieval — Baroque · Palermo — Caltanissetta



For centuries the island's finest confectioners were nuns. Behind grilles and vows, convents perfected cannoli, cassata and marzipan fruit.

The sweets were sold through a turnstile window — the ruota — to fund the houses. Pleasure was produced by enclosure, and passed to the world without a face.

HISTORY / 03

A Carnival Luxury

Carnival season · Sicily



The cannolo began as a treat of Carnevale, the brief season of excess before Lent's restraint.

The shell was fried hard and filled only at the last moment, so it stayed crisp against the cool ricotta. It was food for a feast day: rich, loud, and short-lived on purpose.

HISTORY / 04

The Taste of the Island

19th century — today · Sicily — the world



As convent kitchens faded, the recipe passed to town pastry shops and family trade, and the cannolo left the calendar of feast days to belong to any ordinary afternoon.

Today it travels the world as shorthand for Sicilian pleasure — dolce far niente, the sweetness of doing nothing, folded into one crisp shell.

AFTERTASTE

A carnival treat had become the taste of Sicily itself.

A SMALL PRACTICE

Make something beautiful without waiting for a special occasion. Let pleasure exist without turning it into a reward.

What small pleasure have you postponed until life becomes less busy?

RECIPE / INGREDIENTS

Simple Ricotta Cannoli

A simplified home version using ready-made shells.

- 8 ready-made cannoli shells
- 300 g ricotta
- 80 g powdered sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- zest of 1 orange or lemon
- 40 g chopped pistachios or dark chocolate
- extra powdered sugar



RECIPE / METHOD

- 01 Drain the ricotta if necessary.
 - 02 Mix ricotta, sugar, vanilla, and citrus zest.
 - 03 Fold in pistachios or chocolate.
 - 04 Chill for 20–30 minutes.
 - 05 Fill the shells shortly before serving.
 - 06 Dust lightly with powdered sugar.
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A cannolo takes minutes to fill, but the sweetness inside it was assembled over a thousand years.

A BOOK OF TASTE / III

The Patisserie of the Unconscious

Napoleon

CELEBRATION



*Sometimes love is measured in the number of
layers.*

HISTORY / 01

The Thousand Leaves

18th — 19th century · France



The cake descends from the French mille-feuille — the 'thousand leaves' — thin sheets of puff pastry layered with pastry cream.

It was a confectioner's showpiece: precise, patient, and built from almost nothing but butter, flour and time.

HISTORY / 02

A Cake Named Napoleon

1912 · Moscow



For the centenary of the 1812 victory over Napoleon, Moscow's bakers cut the mille-feuille into small triangles resembling the emperor's cocked hat.

The joke stuck. A French pastry, renamed for a defeated French general, entered Russian life for good.

HISTORY / 03

The Holiday You Built

Soviet decades · The Soviet home



In the Soviet kitchen the Napoleon became a cake you assembled over two days. Butter was queued for; layers were rolled late into the night.

Scarcity turned dessert into an act of devotion. You could not simply buy the holiday — you made it, one thin layer at a time.

HISTORY / 04

The Family Notebook

Passed by hand · From mother to daughter



The recipe travelled in handwritten notebooks, from mother to daughter and neighbour to neighbour, each hand adjusting it slightly.

Left to rest until morning, the strict layers softened into one tender whole — patience and love pressed into a single slice.

AFTERTASTE

*A cake had become a way of
keeping a family together.*

A SMALL PRACTICE

Create one celebration by hand. Not because it is efficient, but because making something slowly can itself become the event.

*Whose labour made celebration feel effortless to
you?*

RECIPE / INGREDIENTS

Home-Style Napoleon Cake

A home-adapted version built on ready puff pastry.

- 500 g puff pastry
- 500 ml milk
- 3 egg yolks
- 120 g sugar
- 40 g cornstarch
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 150 g butter
- pinch of salt



RECIPE / METHOD

- 01 Bake the puff pastry in thin sheets until golden.
 - 02 Heat most of the milk.
 - 03 Whisk yolks, sugar, cornstarch, salt, and remaining milk.
 - 04 Slowly add the warm milk.
 - 05 Cook on low heat until thick.
 - 06 Add vanilla and cool slightly.
 - 07 Beat in the butter.
 - 08 Layer pastry and cream.
 - 09 Cover with pastry crumbs.
 - 10 Chill overnight.
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The Napoleon is only pastry and cream, but its patience is the whole point — the waiting is the recipe.

A BOOK OF TASTE / IV

The Patisserie of the Unconscious

Tiramisu

CARE



The gentlest luxuries are the ones meant to be shared.

HISTORY / 01

The Pick-Me-Up

Older tradition · The Veneto



Long before the cake, the Veneto had its restoratives: egg yolks beaten with sugar — sbatudìn, zabaione — given to children, the tired, the recovering.

The idea was already there: something soft and sweet and gently strengthening, made at home to lift a body that was flagging.

HISTORY / 02

Born in Treviso

Late 1960s — early 1970s · Treviso



In Treviso, the modern tiramisù took shape — most often credited to the restaurant Le Beccherie and the family and pastry cook behind it.

Mascarpone, espresso-soaked savoiardi, egg, sugar and cocoa were layered into something new. Its name came from the dialect: tirame sù — 'pick me up.'

HISTORY / 03

The Name Travels

1980s · Italy



Printed in cookbooks and copied from kitchen to kitchen, tiramisù spread out of the Veneto and across Italy within a decade.

Every region bent it a little — more coffee, a splash of liqueur, a different biscuit — but the gesture stayed the same.

The World's Dessert

Today · Everywhere



Tiramisù is now perhaps the most recognised Italian dessert on earth, found on menus from Tokyo to Buenos Aires.

For all its fame it kept its humble character: no baking, no spectacle — just coffee, cream and the wish to lift someone's day.

AFTERTASTE

A local pick-me-up had become a way of caring for one another.

A SMALL PRACTICE

Make something for someone who is tired — not to impress them, but simply to lift them. Let the small ritual of coffee and cream be the whole gift.

Who in your life could use a little lifting — and how might a taste say it for you?

Classic Tiramisù

The traditional Italian layered coffee dessert.

- 4 egg yolks
- 100 g sugar
- 500 g mascarpone
- 300 ml strong espresso, cooled
- 200 g savoiardi (ladyfinger biscuits)
- 2 tbsp cocoa powder
- a splash of Marsala or dark rum, optional



RECIPE / METHOD

- 01 Whisk the yolks and sugar until pale and thick.
 - 02 Fold in the mascarpone until smooth.
 - 03 Stir the cooled espresso (and Marsala, if using) in a shallow dish.
 - 04 Dip each ladyfinger briefly — soaked, not soggy.
 - 05 Line a dish with a layer of biscuits.
 - 06 Spread over half the mascarpone cream.
 - 07 Repeat with a second layer of biscuits and cream.
 - 08 Chill at least 4 hours, then dust generously with cocoa before serving.
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Tiramisù is barely cooked at all — its whole art is in the layering, and in who you make it for.

A BOOK OF TASTE / V

The Patisserie of the Unconscious

Petit Four

CEREMONY



*Some worlds become most beautiful just before
they disappear.*

Sugar as Spectacle

16th — 17th century · The European courts



When sugar was rare and costly, it became a way to display power. Banquets ended with sugar sculptures — subtleties — modelled into castles, ships and coats of arms.

To eat sweetness was to consume wealth in plain sight. Refinement itself became the message.

The Theatre of Versailles

Late 18th century · Versailles



At court, dessert was choreography. Pièces montées and glazed miniatures were arranged down mirrored tables in the ceremony of service à la française.

Sweetness performed effortlessness — while concealing the specialised labour, hierarchy and code that produced it.

HISTORY / 03

À Petit Four

The cooling oven · The confectioner's kitchen



The name comes from the 'small oven' — the cooling hearth where confectioners finished their most delicate work after the great bakes.

Each petit four was a tiny composition: sponge, glaze, a single sugar flower — pastry turned into a small aesthetic object.

HISTORY / 04

When the Tables Vanished

1789 and after · France



Within a decade the mirrored tables were gone, and the world that arranged them with such certainty had ended.

The tiny glazed cake survived — carrying, in one bite, the whole doomed elegance of the ancien régime.

AFTERTASTE

A miniature cake had become a way of performing a perfect world.

A SMALL PRACTICE

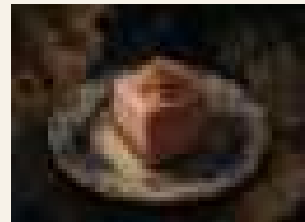
Set a table beautifully for no practical reason, even for one person. Allow beauty to exist without needing to justify it.

What kind of beautiful world have you wanted to be admitted into?

Court-Inspired Petit Fours

A modern fictional recipe inspired by the elegance of late eighteenth-century French confectionery.

- 1 small plain sponge cake or pound cake
- 4 tbsp apricot or raspberry jam
- 150 g powdered sugar
- 2–3 tbsp lemon juice or water
- a small amount of pink food coloring, optional
- edible flowers or sugar decorations



RECIPE / METHOD

- 01 Cut the cake into small neat shapes.
 - 02 Spread a thin layer of jam over the tops.
 - 03 Mix powdered sugar and liquid into a thick glaze.
 - 04 Tint lightly if desired.
 - 05 Glaze the cakes.
 - 06 Allow the glaze to set.
 - 07 Decorate with edible flowers or sugar details.
 - 08 Serve at a table you have arranged for no reason at all.
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A petit four is almost pure surface — and that was always the point: beauty made to be admired before it is eaten.